Walking on Glass

By Alma Fullerton

TRIGGER WARNING: MOTHER'S SUICIDE AND DEATH

[CAUTION - This is a Novel in Verse. Check with your tournament before entering this selection in the POETRY category]

(Pg 4) Writing a journal
for some shrink
won't make me
feel better.
It won't change
what happened.
it'll just make me think,
and I don't want to think.
Mom thought too much.
Look where it got her.

INTRODUCTION

Your mother's suicide attempt has left her in a coma from which she's never waking up. You know that she wouldn't want to live like this, but could you really help her die? The hardest decision of your life, and there's no one to help you . . . It's all up to you.

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(Pg 10) I slouch in a chair
across from Dr. Mac.
He takes my journal
and flips through it
without reading,
like he promised.
"I'm glad you're writing."
He hands it back.
"How's your mother?"
I spin my chair, lean back,
and put my feet up on his desk.
"Same."
He nods, waiting for me to say more.
I don't, making him ask,
"How are you?"
I shrug. "Same."

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(Pg 12) I took the photograph
From the mirror in my mother's room.
Her at the age of eight,
perched high in a tree,
arms stretched out like
an untamed eagle,
prepared to take on
The world.
I keep the picture
in my pocket

so I'll always
remember
the way she was
before she was caged
by a baby
she never wanted.

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(Pg 13) Dad says,
"Come and see Mom."
So I do.
Mom,
tucked tight in the bed,
empty minded.
No longer herself,
or anyone else.
Wires force life into a body
left hanging
like a marionette
With no one to pull
the strings.
Dad leans close to her
and whispers,
"You'll come home soon, dear.
Everything will be better."
I know he really
wants that
to be true,

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but the thought of her
coming back
into our lives
makes my insides
flip.

(Pg 16) I don't want her to die.
I just want
it all to
stop.
Does that make me
so terrible?

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(Pg 35-36) The beeping
from her machines
shrieks.
A reminder
her soul is tethered to the ground,
a captive falcon,
circling in confusion,
longing for someone
to set it
free.
. . . and I think maybe sometimes
nonexistence
is better than being
caged.

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I stand watching her.
I want to smack her
for putting us through this.
I want to scream,
"Why didn't you want to live
You're supposed to want to stay here
with us!"
If she's going to die,
she should get it over with
and just
do
it.

(Pg 45) I stand over Mom,
shaking inside,
and wonder why she did it.
Why she didn't think about anyone
but herself.
Why she didn't think
about us.
Why she didn't think
about me.

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(Pg 48-49) Nurses lurk
around Mom's bed
like vultures.
But Dad guards her --
a lion

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ready to pounce on
the vultures as they swoop
to take away his mate.
He doesn't seem to know
what the vultures
already know.

She's gone.

If Mom came home,
things wouldn't change.
Her mood would always flip
from bad to worse
in a matter of seconds,
and for the rest of our lives
Dad and I would
be walking on
shards of glass
from a broken
chandelier.

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(Pg 56) My teacher asks everyone,
"If you could change
anything in history,
what would it be?"

Kids say things like,
I'd prevent wars
or Bin Laden and Hitler

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wouldn't have been born.
Other kids not their heads to agree.
When the teacher asks me,
I say,
"Four months ago,
I would have come home
five minutes earlier."
Everyone looks away from me
like my face is on
sideways.

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(Pg 58) It's too quiet
at home,
and it smells different.

There's no longer
the scent of fresh flowers
Mom always kept
in the living room.
Instead I smell
dust, rot, and
even after cleaning the floor,
blood.
Why can I still smell
the blood?

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(Pg 64) As I sit on the couch
staring at a cushion,

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in silence,
I keep seeing Mom
curled up and gripping
this cushion on this couch,
alone,
crying
in the dark.
Instead of going to her,
I walked by.
Saying nothing,
like she was invisible.
I hug the cushion
and smell it,
hoping to get a hint
of her perfume,
but it's gone.
. . . I go to my room,
and turn up the music
loud
so I can forget what
I remember.

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(Pg 70) My father
cries out to Mom
in his sleep.
I slide from the warmth
of my bed
to sleep on the bumpy couch

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in the living room,
where I'll no longer
hear his calls.

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(Pg 73) What's left of the
old chandelier
is heaped next to the window.
And once in a while
the sun shines in
and rainbows dance
against the walls.
It's as if the crystals
stole Mom's spirit.
I hang the crystals
by the window
in Mom's room.
I hope they
give her
spirit
back.

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(Pg 82-83) Today
the doctors tell Dad
there's still no hope.
Mom's not getting better.
They ask if he would
consent

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to have the machines
shut down
and donate

Mom's organs.
Dad gets mad.
He refuses to believe
she's gone.
But I'm feeling
more relieved
than mad.

God, Forgive Me . . .
The thought of my own mother
dying
shouldn't leave the taste of
freedom
in my mouth.

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(Pg 87) Nurses flock
to Mom's room
like she's having a sale
on white sneakers.
In between their visits
I'm alone with her
and her machines.
I reach for the machine
to do what I need to do.

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My hands shake,
and sweat drips
down the back of my legs,
stinging the open blisters
on my heels.
I jerk my hand away,
without even touching
the switch.
I race out of there,
gasping for air,
and throw up on
the shoes I still can't
fill.

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(Pg 93) Dad putters around the house
avoiding me.
I want to get right up
in his face
and scream for him
to be the man he should be
so I won't have to,
but I
can't.

(Pg 95) "I know you think
I'm wrong,"
Dad says.
He looks at me

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over the piles of
takeout containers
on the coffee table.
"I can't let go yet."
I scarf down my
chow-mein noodles
to avoid looking
directly at him.
"It's not my fault. . . ,"
he says.
I glance up.
His eyes water
I focus my attention
on my noodles.
"And I didn't know she was that
unhappy," he says.
I put my plate
across the table.
It tips.
I get up
and walk away,
leaving my dad's heart
and the noodles
spilled all over the floor.

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(Pg 102) As I left the house
that June morning,

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Mom said,
"I love you."
I just closed the door
and left her
alone.
I should have told her
I loved her.
Maybe then
she wouldn't be
in the hospital
today.

****

(Pg 103) I bring Mom
roses.
I watch her carefully,
looking for any clue
she knows I'm with her.
She lies there
lifeless.
I try to swallow the lump
building in my throat,
but it just expands.
The aroma from the roses
filters through the air.
They smell like she used to
when I was small.
Sweet and fresh.

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Their scent
will fade
now that they're
no longer attached
to the roots
which gave them life.
I stare outside
and wonder
if I'll ever have the courage
to cut Mom off
from her roots.

(Pg 106-107) I don't doubt for a second
that most people think
what I want to do
is wrong.
But I don't want to
murder
my mother.
I want to set her
free.
Murder
The unlawful killing of a human
being
with malice
aforethought.
I'm thinking about it.
Does that make it
murder?

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(Pg 119) Mom doesn't have
a future.
Mom doesn't have
a life.
Mom has been dead
for six months.
You can't call
it murder.

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(Pg 112-113) Dad sits beside
Mom's bed.
He strokes her hair
and whispers to her.
He closes his eyes.
Clenching his jaw,
he lets out a sigh.
When he opens his eyes,
a tear drips from each corner.
He shakes his head
and walks out of the room.
I wait for him to come back.
He doesn't.
I wonder
if Dad is torn up inside
for the same reason
I'm torn.

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(Pg 116) Today
Dr. Mac explains how
sick Mom was.
How she needed medicine
to make her feel better,
but she refused to take it
He explains how,
if she did,
she'd still be here.
Today Dr. Mac
explains how
sick Mom was
and how nothing she did
was my
fault.

*****

(Pg 122) **What happened** ???

That day,
I came home and found
a new pair of shoes
by the door.
When I went into the dining room
to tell Mom they were
too big,
mom stepped off of the table.
A noose slung around her neck.

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I caught her
and held her up.
Mom struggled.
She kicked me away.
But I wouldn't
let go.

(Pg 109) Sometimes I wish
I hadn't held Mom up.
Then it would have
all been over
that rainy June day.

(Pg 122) [But] I wanted to tell her
I loved her.
I wanted to tell her
I needed her.
I wanted to tell her
to stay with us.
The wires holding
the chandelier snapped
and it crashed on top of her head,
and my arm broke
and I dropped her.
Her blood splattered
all over my new shoes.

****

(Pg 125) I remember

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her soft voice
floating through the air
like the smell of fresh roses,
as she sings me a lullaby
to take away
the monsters in the night.
I remember
her dimpled smile,
her blue eyes,
her gentle touch.
I remember
my mother,
the way she was.

****

(Pg 130) [It's] **Mom's birthday**

The doctors take
Dad into another room,
leaving me alone
with the shell
of my mother.
I brush the hair from her face
and rest my hand
on her forehead.
I sit,
listening to the machines
as their parts move,
and I'm no longer afraid.

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I bend
and kiss my mother's cheek.
"I will always love you, Mom."
I reach over
and shut
off
the machine.
When I open the door
to leave,
I notice,
I finally fit
into the shoes
my mother gave me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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